

Anaphors before intensifiers: The emergence of *nafs-x* in Hebrew and Arabic

Diachronic studies of the English *x-self* anaphor observe that its source is a focused expression known as ‘emphatic reflexive’ or ‘intensifier’ (as in *the queen herself came*). In Old English, intensifiers existed as independent *self* morphemes which facilitated local coreference in otherwise ambiguous pronouns. This process has so far been considered universal and motivated a pragmatic framing of reflexive anaphors, where they emerge to reduce ambiguity in the discourse. This paper shows evidence from Hebrew and Arabic that a reversed path of change is also attested, where the coreferential use of anaphors anticipates the intensifier use. This path calls to reconsider the pragmatic motivation observed in English as a trigger for the emergence of anaphors cross-linguistically.

1. Introduction

Reflexive anaphors have been a focus of interest in formal linguistics due to their role in regulating coreference. A basic demonstration is given in (1): the anaphor *herself* must be construed as referring to the local subject *the queen*, while the pronoun *her* is understood to be somebody else.

- (1) a. *The queen₁ invited {herself₁/*her₁} to the party.*
a. *The queen₁ invited {*herself₂/her₂} to the party.*

This division of labour was one of the central puzzles faced by Government and Binding Theory (Chomsky 1981, 1986) and many accounts since. A separate puzzle relates specifically to morphologically complex anaphors, which often have a parallel use that serves as a form of emphasis (capital letters mark focus accent):

- (2) a. *The queen HERSELF came to the party.*
b. *The queen signs official letters HERSELF.*

Here, *herself* does not affect the truth value of the sentence and instead triggers inferences regarding other entities that attended the party, or that could be signing letters. The following sentences show that these inferences resonate with known semantic effects of focus particles: (2a) can be paraphrased as (3a), and (2b) as (3b).

- (3) a. ***Even** the queen came to the party.*
b. ***Only** the queen signs official letters.*

Accordingly, the standard approach to this use of *self* captures its import through operations on contextual alternatives which are fed by focus (Moravcsik 1972; König and Siemund 1996; König and Gast 2006; Cohen 2010). This situates *x-self* as the exponent of two essentially different grammatical objects: a pronoun with a bound-variable interpretation in (1) and an adjectival or adverbial focus operator in (2).

This duality receives a straightforward explanation in diachronic studies starting with Penning (1875), which show that *self* intensifiers are the historical building block of the English *x-self* anaphor. An extensive body of work observes that Old English *self* appears in contexts of locally bound pronouns that would have otherwise been ambiguous between disjointness and local coreference (Farr 1905; Visser 1966; Mitchell 1979; Keenan 1994; König and Siemund 1996; van Gelderen 1996; Peitsara 1997, and many others). Typological models of reflexivity assume similar processes in many other Indo-European languages, and argue that they reflect a general path of historical change (Kemmer 1993; Heine 1999; König and Siemund 2000).

These observations suggest that the anaphor emerges as a reaction to a discourse pressure. Some influential work extends this perspective to synchronic theories of anaphors, claiming that their core linguistic function is discourse oriented (e.g., Ariel 2008; Haspelmath 2008). The current paper argues that this conclusion is premature, since the emergence of the English anaphor is a special case in a more diverse typological picture. Specifically, I show that the history of anaphors in two Semitic languages, Hebrew and Standard Arabic, does not reinforce the intensifier-to-anaphor path but rather show a reverse trajectory: the intensifier meaning arises in the compounded form that had already been established as an anaphor. Moreover, there is indication from philological work that accusative pronouns in these languages were locally disjoint in a predictable fashion, which undermines the idea that resolving ambiguity played a role in the emergence of anaphors in these languages.

My focus is the anaphor *nafs-x*, lit. ‘soul of x’, which appears in various cognates across dialects of Aramaic and Arabic as a reflexive anaphor, an intensifier, and a modifier meaning ‘same’. Examples of the three patterns of use in modern varieties are given in (4).

(4) a. Reflexive (Modern Standard Arabic):

<i>al-xutʕatʕ-u</i>	<i>la</i>	<i>tukarir-u</i>	<i>nafs-a-ha</i> ,
the-plans-NOM	NEG	repeats.3SG.F-IMP	self-ACC-3SG.F
<i>al-ḥurub-u</i>	<i>la</i>	<i>tukarir-u</i>	<i>nafs-a-ha</i> .
the-wars-NOM	NEG	repeat.3SG.F-IMP	self-ACC-3SG.F

‘The plans do not repeat themselves, the wars do not repeat themselves.’

(ArTenTen12)

b. Intensifier (Modern Standard Arabic):

w-al kitab-u al-muqaddas-i nafs-u-hu ōukir-a
 and-the book-NOM the-holy-GEN soul-NOM-3SG.M mentioned.3SG.m-PERF
fi-hi ma-la jaqel ſan ſifrina muḏ‘ahar-at-en.
 in-3SG.M NEG-NEG less from twenty manifestation-PL-INDD
 ‘and the Bible itself mentioned no less than twenty demonstrations.’

(ArTenTen12)

c. ‘same’ (Palestinian Arabic):

nafs l-baḥr we-š-šāt
 soul the-sea and-the-coast
 ‘the same sea and coast’ (Haya Zaatry, حدود ووعود ‘borders and promises’, line 3)

I examined ‘soul’ expressions in closed corpora of two related languages: The Hebrew Bible (Biblical Hebrew, first millennium BCE) and the Qur’an (Classical Arabic, 609-632 CE). Both sources predate the convention of a reflexive anaphor in either language. The data will show that *nafs-x* is used in both languages to denote coreference well before its use as an intensifier is attested, with evidence from Jewish Babylonian Aramaic suggesting a similar trend (Bar-Asher Siegal 2013). The modifier use of *nafs* with the meaning ‘same’ is unattested in the examined corpora, pointing to the following chronological trajectory.

(5) ‘soul’ > anaphor > intensifier > ‘same’

The existence of this path suggests that the emergence of anaphors in the world’s languages cannot be reduced to the particular discourse pressure of resolving the ambiguity between local and long-distance coreference. Instead, it seems that multiple pressures across different language families lead to the same division of labour between anaphors and pronouns.

The remainder of the introduction outlines the received wisdom on the development of the English anaphor (Section 1.1) and provides some background on the Semitic ‘soul’ anaphor (Section 1.2). Upcoming sections present results from the corpora surveys (Section 2), discuss the theoretical implications of the findings (Section 3) and conclude (Section 4).

1.1 Complex anaphors in the history of English

The extensive diachronic literature on English *x-self* plays a major role in the current understanding of how anaphors develop historically (Penning 1875; Farr 1905; Visser 1966; Mitchell 1979; Keenan 1994; König and Siemund 1996; van Gelderen 1996; Peitsara 1997, and many others). Specifically, historical corpora show that English anaphors have emerged

within a system in which pronouns are free to express any type of reference rather than being limited by Principle B of the Binding Theory. To illustrate, in (6), the accusative pronoun *hine* corefers with the local subject *Adam*.

- (6) Local coreference in Old English pronouns (König and Siemund 2000: 32a):

Ða behydde Adam hine & his wif eac swa dyde.
 and hide Adam him.ACC and his wife also same did
 “and Adam hid himself and his wife did the same”

The morpheme *self* exists independently in Old English as an adjective that evokes focus inferences, seen below adjacent to a noun (7a), a pronoun, (7b), and a verb (7c). As indicated by the translations, Old English *self* has similar conditions of use to that of the Modern English *x-self* intensifier. That is, as an intensifier, *self* has generally retained its interpretive and distributional properties, and I will take for granted that existing analyses of Modern English intensifier (e.g., by König and Siemund 1996 and subsequent work) trace back to its predecessor.

- (7) *self* in Old English (van Gelderen 2000: 80-81, König and Siemund 2000:48):

a. <i>ond se cyning sylfa.</i>	b. <i>swa he self gecwæð</i>	c. <i>ac he him sylf gewat</i>
and the king SELF	as he SELF says	but he him SELF depart
‘And the king himself.’	‘as he himself says.’	‘but he died alone’

The cited work shares the observation that intensifiers joining pronouns strengthen their locally dependent reading over an independent discourse reference. Representative examples are given in (8a-b).

- (8) a. *Judas hine selfne aheng.*

Judas him.ACC self.ACC hang

‘Judas hung himself.’

(Visser 1966 p.423)

- b. *tat he hyne sylfne gewrac*

that he him-ACC self-ACC avenged

‘He avenged himself.’

(van Geledern 2000: 34)

The frequency of *self* in the context of locally bound pronouns gradually increased words between the years 1250 and 1700 CE from 0.16 to 1.20 instance per 1000 (Keenan 1994; Peitsara 1997; Lange 2001). This increase came at the expense of coreferential uses of bare pronouns, which dropped from 1.33 per 1000 words to near zero. During the same period, *self* migrated from the adjectival domain to the nominal, lost case and person declensions and became one prosodic word with the adjacent pronoun. The pronominal

system of English stabilized around 1600 CE, with *him* and *himself* becoming designated forms for disjoint and coreferential readings, respectively. A complementary process has turned the intensifier into a complex form analogous to the anaphor.

This process predicts the surface similarity between anaphors and intensifiers, which is in no way unique to the Indo-European language family. König & Siemund (2013) found that 56% of a representative sample of 168 languages exhibit some formal identity between anaphors and intensifiers. This rate effectively means that a homophony between anaphors and intensifiers is more common than the alternative where the two are unrelated.

A common semantic explanation for this pattern is that anaphors and intensifiers share the same core meaning that is an expression of identity between individuals in a sentence (in anaphors) or across focus alternatives (in intensifiers) (Hole 2006, Eckardt 2001, König & Gast 2006, Reuland & Winter 2009). This leaves room for the possibility that some languages arrive at a homophonous pattern through the reverse trajectory, in which the identity operator emerges within the pronominal system and only later acquires the pragmatic function of focus-based inferences.

The idea that anaphors may emerge directly from body-parts has been raised by Faltz (1977), causing König & Siemund (2000) to define the intensifier as an optional step. An alternative in which some anaphors develop parallel to the intensifier is entertained in Anghelescu (2011) for Classical Arabic and in Amiridze & Leuschner (2002) and Evseeva & Salaberri (2018) for Georgian. My interpretation of the data presented below will go a step further to suggest that intensifiers may emerge from anaphors, expanding the typological picture.

1.2 ‘Soul’ anaphors in Semitic languages

The Semitic anaphor *nafs-x*, lit. ‘soul of x’, represent a different morphological type from the English counterpart, although both belong to the class of complex anaphors. In English, this complex is headed by a pronoun and adjoined by a *self* morpheme, while Semitic anaphors are constructed the other way around: the body term is the head. The following figure locates the two anaphoric elements within the typology of reflexive constructions laid out by Faltz (1977) (see Kemmer 1993; Janic, Puddu, and Haspelmath 2023 for more nuanced distinctions).

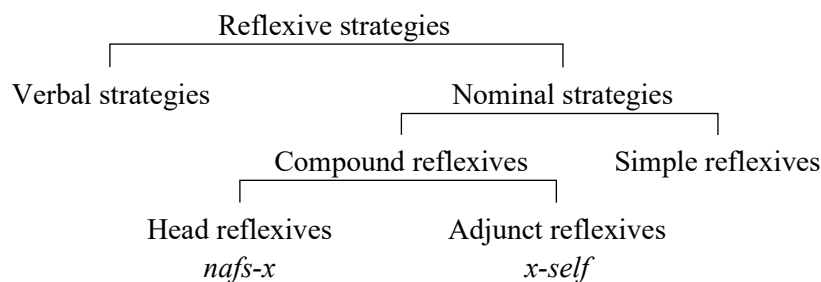


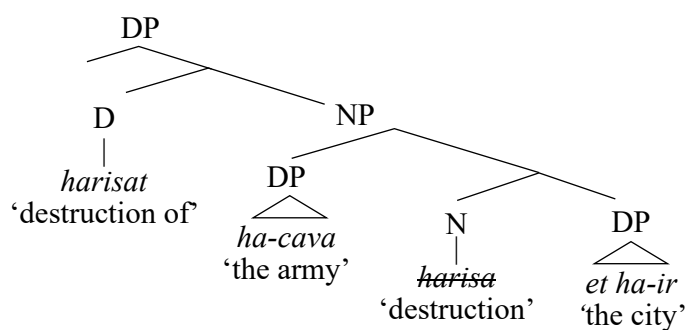
Figure 1: A typology of reflexive constructions (based on Faltz 1977)

The division into head and adjunct reflexives largely correlates with the split in the lexical source of the reflexive morpheme. Adjunct reflexivizers are often intensifiers, as seen in English, while many head reflexivizers derive from body terms or from terms of inalienable possession more broadly. In the Semitic context, reflexive morphemes take the form of body parts in a possessive structure known as the construct state, a nominal compound in which a prenominal DP is understood as a possessee. The standard syntax of this construction, illustrated in (9), has the head noun accepting possessed status by raising to D, which is reflected in a morphological alternation (Ritter 1988; Borer 1988, 1999, 2008; Heller 2002; Fassi Fehri 2004; Siloni 1997; Ouwayda 2012; cf. Shlonsky 2012 for a base-generated alternative).

(9) Modern Hebrew:

harisat ha-cava et ha-ir

‘The army’s destruction of the city’



The typical Semitic anaphor follows a version of this structure in which the possessor is a pronominal suffix, e.g., *nafsa-hu* ‘his soul’ (Standard Arabic), *acm-o* ‘his bone’, *ras-u* ‘his head’ (Amharic), which form paradigms inflecting for person, gender, and number.

	Modern Hebrew	Standard Arabic	Palestinian Arabic	Amharic (Leslau 1995)
1 SG	<i>acm-i</i> ‘my bone’	<i>nafs-i</i> ‘my soul’	<i>ḥal-i</i> ‘my state’	<i>ras-e</i> ‘my head’
2 SG.F/M	<i>acm-ex/exa</i>	<i>nafs-uki/uka</i>	<i>ḥal-ek/ak</i>	<i>ras-əš/əh</i>
3 SG.F/M	<i>acm-a/o</i>	<i>nafs-uha/uhu</i>	<i>ḥal-ha/a</i>	<i>ras-wa/u</i>
1 PL	<i>acm-enu</i>	<i>nafs-una</i>	<i>ḥa:l-na</i>	<i>ras-aččən</i>
2 PL.F/M	<i>acm-exen/exem</i>	<i>‘anfs-ukunna/ukum</i>	<i>ḥal-ku</i>	<i>ras-aččə^wh</i>
3 PL.F/M	<i>acm-an/am</i>	<i>nafs-uhunna/uhum</i>	<i>ḥal-hen</i>	<i>ras-aččāw</i>

Table 1: Semitic Body part anaphors.

The ‘soul’ lexeme is a particularly common base for Semitic anaphors, documented since at least the 7th century BCE in Egyptian Aramaic (Muraoka and Porten 2015), with cognates in Classical Mandaic (Macuch 1965), Classical Arabic, Iraqi Arabic, Syrian Arabic, Egyptian Arabic, Syriac Aramaic, Christian Palestinian Aramaic, Neo-West Aramaic, Biblical Hebrew, Ge‘ez, Tigré, Tigrinya and Modern Standard Arabic (Rubin 2005). Its early lexical meanings include the concepts ‘breath’, ‘life’, and the centre of emotions (Urbach 1985, François 2008).

Since ‘soul’ anaphors are also used as intensifiers, they provide an opportunity to test whether the historical trajectory that is observed in English extends to Semitic languages. My goal was to see whether the intensifier meaning that is associated with ‘soul’ anaphors in modern Arabic varieties was available to speakers during the emergence of the anaphoric use. The upcoming section shows that there is little to no evidence of ‘soul’ lexemes having an intensifier function prior to their use as an anaphor.

2. Data

The core question that led the current survey was whether anaphors in Hebrew and Standard Arabic start out as anaphors or as intensifiers. Modern dialects of these languages employ the respective anaphors *acm-x* ‘bone of x’ and *nafs-x* ‘soul of x’ as primary strategies of reflexivity and intensification. Philological work observe that the predecessors Biblical Hebrew and Qur’anic Arabic have no designated anaphor system (Gesenius 1813; Wright 1898; Joüon 1923; Sarfatti 1992; Jones 2017). These languages express reflexivity mainly in the verb, alongside a limited use of a collection of body terms including the cognates *nap̄š* and *nafs*, as well as *qereḇ* ‘innards’, *lēḇ* ‘heart’ and *rō’š* ‘head’ in Hebrew, *ʕajien* ‘eye’ and *waḍḥ* ‘face’ in Arabic. Part of the evidence come from correspondences between ‘soul’ constructions and reflexive verbs, illustrated in Table 2.

L	Active	Reflexive	<i>nafs-</i>
Hebrew	<i>inna</i> ‘tortured’	<i>hit’anna</i> ‘tortured himself’	<i>inna (’ēt) nap̄šo</i> ‘tortured himself’
	<i>ṭimme’</i> ‘defiled’	<i>niṭma’</i> ‘defiled himself’	<i>ṭimme’ (’ēt) nap̄šo</i> ‘defiled himself’
Arabic	<i>zakkā</i> ‘purified’	<i>Tazakkā</i> ‘purified himself’	<i>zakkā nafsahū</i> ‘purified himself’

Table 2: Reflexive verbs and *nafs* constructions in the Bible and Qur’an (Gesenius 1813, Kayam 2023).

nafs-x starts appearing in grammars of Classical Arabic as a prominent anaphoric strategy for sources starting at the late 8th century (Fischer 1972), which is some 100 years after the

appearance of the Qur'anic text. There is no documentation of Hebrew *nap̄š-x* becoming such a convention in Biblical Hebrew. The language ceased to be spoken in the first century CE and was succeeded by Rabbinic Hebrew, which has inherited *acm-x* in both its anaphoric and intensifier uses as a loan translation from Jewish Palestinian Aramaic. Based on this information, I assume that the Biblical and the Qur'anic texts provide snapshots of the process in which Semitic anaphors/intensifiers emerged from their body-part source.

2.1 Methodology

I collected instances of the Biblical *nepeš* (נֶפֶשׁ) and Qur'anic *naḥs* (نَفْس) using Logos Bible software¹ and almaany.com in base form and in the construct state, with all possible pronominal suffixes. I classified the results through manual encoding according to their meaning in context, following standard analyses of reflexive anaphors and intensifiers. A data point was considered anaphoric when it coreferred with a local c-commanding DP, and an intensifier when the context evoked alternative entities (Chomsky 1981; König and Siemund 1996). I determined the meaning of verses containing *nepeš* and *naḥs* based on common interpreters, consultation with Bible and Qur'an scholars, and a comparison of multiple translations to English.

I kept track of the distribution of instances across generally-accepted chronological division of the corpora: for the Bible, the periods known as Classical and Late Biblical Hebrew, which are divided in accordance with the historical exile of Jewish scholarly elite to Babylon during the 6th century BCE (Fassberg 2016; Hendel and Joosten 2018); for the Qur'anic, the sub-periods suggested by al-Zanjānī (1353/1935) (quoted in Karimi-Nia 2013) and Nöldeke (1860), known as the three Meccan periods (610-622 CE) and the Medina period (622-632 CE) (cf. Robinson 2003; Riddell 2017, Sinai 2018). Both sources showed no significant correlation between chronological period and the meaning breakdown and were excluded from the results section.

The Hebrew data is presented in transliteration conventions of the Society of Biblical Literature, with English translations following the New International Version. The Arabic data is presented in transliteration based on the Encyclopedia of Arabic language and linguistics (Versteegh, Elgibali, and Zaborski 2009) with English translations by Marmaduke Pickthall unless otherwise stated. Translations were chosen based on their transparency with respect to the literal text. Finally, I consistently gloss *nepeš* and *naḥs* as 'soul' with the intention of remaining

¹ Wicker, J.R. (2003) Logos Bible software. Series X. Biblical languages supplement. Southwestern Journal of Theology, 46, 96-97.

neutral with respect to the existence the concept of a soul in the Modern English sense in these languages and with respect to the particular meanings these expressions get in context.

2.2 Biblical *neṣeš*

I extracted a total of 754 occurrences of *neṣeš* and the construct-state form *naṣš-* from the Hebrew Bible (Masoretic Text). The most prevalent contexts, illustrated below, were of emotions (10), desires (11) and ‘life’ as a state (12) or an entity (13).

(10) *Emotions:*

‘al miškāb-ī, bal-lēylōt, biqqaštī, ’ēl še-’āhābā naṣš-ī;
 on bed.of-1SG in.the-nights request.1SG ACC that-love.3SG.F soul.of-1SG
biqqašt-ī-w, wə-lō’ māsā’-tī-w
 request-1SG-3SG.M and-NEG find-1SG-3SG.M
 ‘All night long on my bed I looked for the one my heart loves; I looked for him but did not find him.’ (Song of songs 3:1)

(11) *Desire:*

kī tābō’ bə-kerem rē’ē-kā wə-’ākaltā
 if come.2SGM in-vineyard.GEN neighbor.of-2SGM and-eat.2SGM
’ānābīm kə-naṣš-akā šāb’ē-kā wə-’el kelay-kā
 grapes as-soul.of-2SG.M satiation.of.2SG.M and-to vessel.of-2SG.M
lō’ tittēn.
 NEG put.2SGM
 ‘If you enter your neighbor’s vineyard, you may eat all the grapes you want, but do not put any in your basket.’ (Deuteronomy 23:25, New International version)

(12) *Life:*

wə-’attāh yəhwāh qah-nā ’ēl naṣš-ī mimmenī:
 and-now Lord take-therefore ACC soul.of-1SG from.1SG
kī tōv mōt-ī mē-ḥayyāy
 because good death.of-1SG from-life.of.1SG
 ‘Now, Lord, take away my life, for it is better for me to die than to live.’ (Jonah 4:3)

(13) *u-makkē neṣeš bəhēmā yəšallmēnna neṣeš taḥat neṣeš.*

and-hit.3SG.M soul beast pay.3SG.M soul for soul
 ‘Anyone who takes the life of someone’s animal must make restitution, a life for a life.’ (Leviticus 24:18)

In General, occurrences of *neṣṣ* next to overt determiners, numerals, or quantifiers are interpreted as ‘person’ in singular, plural, or mass (*ha-neṣṣ* ‘the people’, lit: ‘the soul’), or as an indefinite pronoun: the quantified expressions *neṣṣ aḥat* ‘one soul’ and *kol neṣṣ* ‘every soul’) are interpreted as ‘someone’ and ‘everyone’, respectively. This is shown clearly in contexts like the following, in which *neṣṣ aḥat* is ordered to perform a physical act of sacrificing a goat and hence is more compatible with the meanings ‘any person’ or ‘anyone’ than ‘any soul’.

- (14) *wə-’im neṣṣ ’aḥat teḥēṭā’ bi-šgāgāh wə-hiqrībā*
 and-if soul one.SG.F sin.3SG.F in-error and-sacrifice.3SG.F
’ēz baṭ šənāṭā lə-ḥattā’
 goat aged.SG.F year to.sin
 ‘And if any soul sins through ignorance, then he shall bring a she goat of the first
 year for a sin offering.’ (Numbers 15:27)

In terms of reference, I found all instances of *neṣṣ* in base form to be locally disjoint, as expected following Binding Principle C. Suffixed forms were often coreferential at the suffix level, seen below in the context of the emotional interpretation of *neṣṣ* (15a) and the ‘life’ interpretation (15b). The English translations of such expressions vary between ‘x’s soul/life’ and ‘x-self’.

- (15) Coreferential use of *naṣṣ-x*:
- a. *wə-lō təṭamm ’ū ’et naṣṣ-ōt-ēxem bə-kol haš-šereš*
 and-NEG defile.2PL.M ACC soul-PL-GEN.2PL.M in-all the-insect
hā-rōmēš ’al hā-’āreš.
 COMP-swarm.3PL.M on the-ground
 ‘Do not make {your spirit/yourselves} unclean by any creature that moves along
 the ground.’ (Leviticus 11:44)
- b. *hinnē hāyū kə-kaš ’ēš šrāfāt-am, lō yaššilū ’et*
 here were as-straw fire burn.3SG.F-them NEG save.3PL.M ACC
naṣṣ-ām miy-yad lehābā;
 soul-GEN.3PL.M from-hand.of flame
 ‘Surely they are like stubble; the fire will burn them up. They cannot even save
 {their lives/themselves} from the power of the flame.’ (Isaiah 47:14)

Importantly, all the coreferential instances I retrieved fit one of the lexical meanings of *neṣeš*. This indicates that the expression has not reached the status of modern Semitic anaphors, which are bleached of their body term meaning. Of the suffixed forms, 55 ‘soul’ instances (i.e., emotions and desires) were coreferential with a local c-commanding antecedent and 67 locally disjoint. Suffixed instances meaning ‘life’ were divided between 45 coreferential and 73 disjoint instances. This reflects a rather substantial rate of 41.7% locally bound instances among the suffixed forms. A summary of the results from the Biblical corpus are presented in Table 3.

Form	Meaning	Ref.	Count	Example	Source
Base	throat	disjoint	2	<i>kī ḥā’ū mayīm ‘ad nāṣēš</i> ‘for water came unto the throat’	Psalm 69:2
	person	disjoint	120	<i>’im neṣēš ‘aḥaṭ teḥēṭā’ bi-šgāgāh</i> ‘if a person sins through error’	Num. 15:27
	soul	disjoint	288	<i>wat-tiqṣar neṣēš-hā’ām</i> ‘the people grew impatient’	Num. 21:4
	life	disjoint	105	<i>neṣēš taḥaṭ nāṣēš</i> ‘a life for a life’	Lev. 24:18
Suffixed	soul	disjoint	67	<i>rabbīm ōmrīm lə-naṣšī</i> ‘many say of my soul’	Psalm 3:3
		coref.	55	<i>’innītem ‘et naṣšōtēkem</i> ‘(you) torture your souls’	Lev. 16:31
	life	disjoint	73	<i>qah-nā’et naṣšī</i> ‘take my life’	Jonah 4:3
		coref.	45	<i>mallīṭū naṣšōkem</i> ‘(you) save your lives’	Jer. 48:6
total			754		

Table 3: The distribution of meanings and reference type of *neṣeš* in the Bible.

For comparison, suffixed instances of the lexeme ‘heart’ – *lib-x* – present local coreference in Bible in 66 out of 249 instances, which make only 26.51%. The difference in coreference rates between ‘heart of x’ and ‘soul of x’ is statistically significant according to a chi-square test ($\chi^2(1, N = 555) = 24.88, p < .00001$), confirming the privileged status of the ‘soul’ lexeme as a reflexive strategy, as noted by multiple Bible scholars (Gesenius 1813; Sarfatti 1992; Jones 2017).

I found no intensifier use of *neṣeš* (i.e., instances that evoke alternative entities). One suspected exception was found in the expression *šilaxta le-naṣša* lit. ‘release her to her soul’, which is a frozen expression in Modern Hebrew that means ‘leave her to her own devices’. In

this phrase, the meaning of *nap̄š* parallels ‘alone’, which fits the semantic field of intensifiers. However, traditional commentators on the Bible such as Ibn Ezra, as well as translators to English (e.g., King James translation) interpret *nap̄ša* here as ‘her will’.

- (16) *wə-hāyā ’im-lō’ ḥāp̄aštā bāh, wə-šilaḥt-āh lə-nap̄š-ā*
 and-was if-NEG want.2SG.M her and-send.2SG.M-her to-soul-GEN.3SG.F
 ‘And it shall be, if thou have no delight in her, then thou shall
 let her go whither she will.’ (Deuteronomy 21.14)

To conclude, Biblical ‘soul’ expressions divide between meanings of emotions and desires on the one hand and life and living beings on the other. Its base form also includes bleached meanings that read as ‘person’ or an indefinite pronoun. Coreferential uses are nonetheless limited to either emotion or life contexts. Such uses amount to almost half of all suffixed forms but overall serve as a minor reflexive strategy with 0.18 instances per 1,000 words, resembling the frequency of coreferential pronoun-*self* instances reported by Keenan (1994) and others for Early Modern English.

2.3 Qur’anic *nafs*

I extracted 293 occurrences of *nafs* and the plural form *anfus* in their base and suffixed forms. Base form instances (86) were divided between the following meanings: (i) emotions, desires, and psychological experiences, which I refer to collectively as ‘soul’ (67 instances); (ii) life and living entities (17 instances); (iii) breath (2 instances). My investigation of the contexts was based on consultation with Qur’an scholars and an aggregation of over 40 translations to English (see appendix a) shows that the majority of the base form instances can also be interpreted as ‘person’ or an indefinite pronoun, including 55 of ‘soul’ instances and 14 of ‘life’ instances. This suggests that a ‘person’ interpretation of these forms is highly accessible and occasionally preferred (see Kayam 2024), and yet I found no ‘person’ instances that were completely detached from the lexical meaning of *nafs* as found for the Biblical cognate (see above in 14).

The suffixed forms included 122 ‘soul’ instances and 16 ‘life’ instances, the majority of which were coreferential: 91 out of 122 and 13 out of 15, respectively. Another 59 instances were coreferential and did not fit any of the lexical meanings of *nafs*, which I classified as reflexive anaphors. These cases were still limited to animate antecedents. Overall, locally coreferential instances of *nafs-x* make up 83.84% of the suffixed cases.

(17) *Emotions:*

fa-'awjasa fī nafs-i-hī hīfatan mūsā.

so-sensed in soul-GEN-3SG.M fear Mussa.

‘and Moses conceived a fear in his soul.

(Qur'an 20:67)

(18) *Thoughts:*

yuh'fūna fī 'anfus-i-him mā lā yubdūna la-ka.

conceal.3PL.M in soul-GEN-3PL.M what NEG show.3PL.M to-2SG.M

‘They conceal in their souls what they show not to you’

(Qur'an 3:154)

(19) *Life:*

ḍaraba la-kum mathalan min anfus-i-kum

give.3SG.M to-2PL.M example from soul-GEN-2PL.M

‘He gives you an example from your own lives’

(Qur'an 30:28, Malik 1997)

(20) *Person:*

'alimat nafsun mā qaddam-at wa-aḥḥar-at

know soul.NOM what before-3PL.F and-after-3PL.F

‘A soul will know what it hath sent before (it) and what left behind’ (Qur'an 82:5)

(21) *Reflexive anaphor:*

a. *wa-alladīna tad'ūna min dūn-i-hi lā yastaṭī'ū-na*

and-those.that invoke.2SG from without-GEN-3SG.M NEG can-3PL.M

*naṣra-kum wa-lā **anfus-a-hum** yaṣsurū-na.*

help.3PL.M-2PL.M and-NEG soul.PL-ACC-3PL.M help-3PL

‘But those you call upon besides Him, are unable to help you,

and indeed to help themselves’

(Qur'an 7.197)

b. *wa-iḍ axad-nā mīṭāq-a-kum lā tasfikūna dimā'-akum*

and-when take-1PL covenant.ACC-GEN.2PL NEG shed.2PL blood-ACC-GEN.2PL.M

*wa-lā tuxrijūna **anfus-a-kum** min diyār-i-kum*

and-NEG evict.2PL soul.PL-ACC-2PL.M from home-GEN-2PL.M

tumma aqrartum wa-antum tašhadūna.

then ratified and-you.PL witness.2PL

‘When we took a covenant from you: ‘You shall not shed one another's blood,

and shall not drive one another from your dwellings - whereupon you

acknowledged it; and thereto you bear witness’

(Qur'an 2.84)

I found no instances of *nafs* as an adnominal or adverbial intensifier and no pre-nominal ‘same’ uses. I looked further to see whether the semantic operation of intensifier exists for *nafs* in other configurations. That is, I looked for cases in which *nafs* can be construed as making an inference pertaining to alternative entities mentioned in nearby clauses. This examination retrieved 15 instances, some of which are in Table 4.

Source	Context	Alternatives
Q 41:53	<i>mā ’ašhadtuhum ḥalqa s-samāwāti wa-l- ’arḍi wa-lā ḥalqa ’anfusihi</i> ‘I did not make them witnesses of the creation of the heavens and earth, neither of the creation of themselves’	Heavens and earth
Q 7:197	<i>lā yastaṭī ’ūna naṣrakum walā anḥusahum yaṣsurūn</i> ‘They cannot help you, nor can they help themselves’	You
Q 5:25	<i>innī lā amliku illā naḥsī wa-akhī fa-uf’ruq baynanā wabayna l-qawmi l-fāsiqīn</i> ‘I have control of none but myself and my brother, so distinguish between us and the wrong-doing folk’	Wrong-doing folk

Table 4: Instance of *nafs*-x with possible inference related to alternative entities.

These instances are connected to the lexical meaning of *nafs* and are divided between locally coreferential (6 instances) and disjoint contexts (9 instances). The coreferential instances appear in most translations as an anaphor. This is also true for the disjoint cases, which leads to an irregular use of the anaphor in the English translations, as seen in the following example from Pickthall’s translation for Surah 57.

- (22) *mā ’aṣāba min muṣibatīn fī l- ’arḍi wa-lā fī ’anfusi-kum.*
 NEG befell from disaster in DET-earth and-NEG in soul.PL-GEN-2PL.M
 ‘Naught of disaster befalleth in the earth or in **yourselves.**’ (Qur’an 57:22)

Kayam (2024) classifies some of these cases as regular pronouns and I adopt this classification for all the disjoint cases that do not fit clearly into one of *nafs*’s lexical meanings. It seems that an inference related to alternative entities is the most likely trigger for the choice of a *nafs* expression over a pronoun. These instances could be precursors of intensifier *nafs*-x, before it became available as an adjective. Table 5 summarizes the findings.

Form	Meaning	Ref.	Count	Alt.	Example	Source
Base	breath	disj.	2		<i>ṣubḥi idā tanaffas</i> ‘and the <u>breath</u> of morning’	81:18
	soul	disj.	67		<i>ḥājatan fī nafsi ya ‘qūba</i> ‘it was but a <u>need</u> of Jacob's soul’	12:68
	life	disj.	17		<i>n-nafsa bin-nafsi wal- ‘ayna bil- ‘ayni</i> ‘the <u>life for the life</u> and the eye for the eye’	5:45
Suffixed	soul	disj.	32		<i>bimā lā tahwā anfusukumu</i> ‘that your <u>souls</u> had no desire for’ (Arberry 1996)	2:87
		coref.	91		<i>wa-in tub'dū mā fī anfusikum aw tukh'fūhu</i> ‘and whether ye make known what is in your <u>minds</u> or hide it’	2:284
	life	disj.	3		<i>l-laha ish'tarā mina l-mu'minīna anfusahum wa-amwālahum</i> ‘Allah hath bought from the believers their lives and their wealth’	9:111
		coref.	13		<i>faḍḍala l-lahu l-mujāhidīna bi-amwālihīm wa-anfusihim ‘alā l-qā ‘idīna darajatan</i> ‘Allah has elevated in rank those who strive with their wealth and their lives above those who stay behind’ (Khattab 2015)	4:95
	Reflexive	coref.	59	7	<i>wayuḥadhirukumu l-lahu naḥsahu</i> ‘God warns you of himself’ (Assami, Kennedy, and Bantley 1997)	2:84
	Pronoun	disj.	8	8	<i>mā aṣāba min muṣībatin fī l-arḍi walā fī anfusikum</i> ‘No disaster strikes in the earth or among <u>you</u> ’ (Kayam 2024)	57:22
	?		1	1	<i>mā yakūnu lī an ubaddila-hu min-til'qāi naḥsī</i> ‘I can’t change it on my own’ (Khattab 2015)	10:15
total			292			

Table 5: The distribution of meanings, reference, and alternatives-based inference of *nafs* in the Qur'an.

3. Discussion

The results reveal several ways in which the emergence of ‘soul’ anaphors in Hebrew and Arabic differs from the general path represented by English *self*. I address each of these below, starting with the bottom line: the pragmatic pressure that was recognized as a trigger for the emergence of anaphors in English — reducing the ambiguity in the discourse — does not apply in Hebrew and Arabic. That is because the suffixed ‘soul’ expressions are less limited in their reference compared to pronouns, which means they expand rather than resolve the reference in positions in which they occur. The reason behind this is that, unlike Old English pronouns, Hebrew and Arabic pronouns appear to be sensitive to violations of Principle B of Government and Binding.

The data presented here calls to accommodate a shift from anaphors to intensifiers due to a joint semantic core, alongside the well-known process that merges intensifiers with pronouns to form anaphors. These processes nonetheless have a shared step, in which existing lexemes (Germanic intensifiers or Semitic body terms) are recruited as exponents for a covaluation morpheme, which operates either on pronouns or on focus alternatives.

3.1 Coreferential *nafs* anticipates the intensifier

Findings from both sources indicate a use of suffixed ‘soul’ expressions as a limited strategy for local binding, as argued before (Gesenius 1813; Wright 1898; Sarfatti 1992; Kayam 2024). I found coreferential instances of Biblical *nap̄š-x* in contexts that fit one of their lexical meanings: emotions, cognitive actions, and events of taking or saving lives. Qur’anic *nafs-x* also occurs in contexts that do not clearly fit into one of these meanings, yet it is still limited to living antecedents. Note that these languages do not mark pronouns for animacy as a rule, and this restriction is evidently absent for anaphors in Modern Standard Arabic (23, repeated from 4) or in Modern Hebrew (24).

(23) Modern Standard Arabic (repeated from 4):

al-hurub-u la tukarir-u nafs-a-ha.
 the-wars-NOM NEG repeat.3SG.F-IMP soul-ACC-3SG.F
 ‘The wars do not repeat themselves’.

(24) Modern Hebrew:

ha-za’am rak mešaxpel et acm-o
 DET-rage only duplicates ACC bone-3SG.M
 ‘The rage only duplicates itself.’

Both historical sources lack intensifier uses of ‘soul’ in the canonical adnominal or adverbial form, again, in contrast with *nafs-x* and *acm-x* in the modern languages. Examples for the modern intensifier use of these lexemes are given respectively in (25-26).

(25) Moderne Standard Arabic (repeated from 4):

w-al kitab-u al-muqaddas-i naḥs-u-hu ḏukir-a
 and-the book-NOM the-holy-GEN soul-NOM-3SG.M mentioned.3SG.m-PERF
fi-hi ma-la jaqel ṣan ṣifrīna muḏṣaharaten.
 in-3SG.M NEG-NEG less from twenty manifestation.PL
 ‘and the Bible itself mentioned no less than twenty demonstrations.’

(26) Modern Hebrew:

ha-malka acm-a ena ašira kfi še-rabim xošvim
 DET-queen bone-3SG.F COP.NEG rich as comp-many.3MS.PL think.MS.PL
 ‘The queen herself is not as rich as many people believe.’

The occasional use of Qur’anic *nafs-x* in contexts that evoke alternative entities surfaces in DP rather than adjective positions and is clearly outnumbered by the coreferential use of the same form. This goes against the Indo-European based zero assumption that the intensifier use of ‘soul’ should feed its anaphoric use. The fact that such uses are found in the Qur’an – where there are anaphoric uses of *nafs-x* that are detached from the lexical meaning – fits a reverse directionality in which the anaphoric use facilitated the intensifier.

Previous findings from the related language of Jewish Babylonian Aramaic, which is dated to the same period as the Qur’an, demonstrate another step in what seems to be a similar historical path. Bar-Asher Siegal’s (2013) grammar of JBA lists the *napša* ‘soul’ with suffix as a reflexive anaphor, noting that it is restricted to human referents, and that it has a rare use as an adnominal intensifier (2013: p.184). The two uses are illustrated respectively in (27-28).

(27) Jewish Babylonian Aramaic:

rav yehuda hava mešayyen napše-h
 Rabbi Yehuda COP distinguish.1SG.M soul-GEN.3SG.M
 ‘Rabbi Yehuda used to distinguish himself’ (Berakhot 30b, Bar-Asher Siegal 2013, p.183)

(28) *ana napš-i ktabit*

I soul-GEN.1SG write
 ‘I myself wrote:’ (Shabbat 105a, Bar-Asher Siegal 2013, p.184)

Sentence (27) shows a clear delexicalized use of ‘soul’, as it cannot mean that the Rabbi distinguishes his emotional centre or his life. Such cases indicate that speakers of JBA interpreted *napša-x* as a reflexive anaphor, as seen for the Qur’an. Based on the examined dialects of Hebrew, Arabic, and Jewish Babylonian Aramaic, it seems intensifier *naḥš-x* requires its anaphoric use to be some steps removed from its lexical meaning. Further research is required to see whether this trend holds in a broader language sample.

3.2 No ambiguity resolution

Another reason to doubt the idea that ‘soul’ expressions had an intensifying meaning prior to their anaphoric use is that they do not seem to facilitate local coreference. An illustration from the Bible is given in (29), where *napšō* has two possible antecedents, David and Saul, of which the more distant antecedent (David) is selected by the context.

(29) Biblical Hebrew:

wa-yar’ dāwid kī-yāšā’ šā’ûl lēḥaqēš ’et- napš-ō
 and-fear.3SG.M David COMP-leave.3SG.M Saul seek.INF ACC soul-GEN.3SG.M
 ‘David₁ feared that Saul₂ came out to kill him₁ (lit. seek his life)’ (Samuel I 23:15)

The Bible features only few such examples where two ϕ -compatible antecedents are available at different distances, and it is impossible to conclude whether they are more likely to show local or long-distance coreference. However, Bible scholars have observed that a simple pronoun, without *napš*, would have been more restricted in this environment. Gesenius (1813) reports only five instances in which accusative pronouns are interpreted locally in the entire corpus – Jeremiah 7:19, and Ezekiel 43:2,8,10 – three of which repeat the phrase in (30).

(30) *yir’û hā-rō’îm ’ôṭām, wə-’et šō’n-î lō’ rā’û.*
 herd DET-shepherds them and-ACC sheep.MASS-1SG NEG herd
 ‘The shepherds fed themselves, and fed not my sheep’ (Ezekiel 34:8)

Three additional instances (Numbers 6:13, Leviticus 22:19, Deuteronomy 34:6) are mentioned in Sarfatti (1992), following liturgical scholars known as Chazal or The Sages. If these observations are correct, a pronoun appearing as a complement of the verb ‘seek’ in (29) would be likely to have only one possible antecedent in the sentence, the more distant one. In other words, pronouns in these sentences follow Principle B, which is unexpected for a system that does not include a reflexive anaphor. That is due to a broadly accepted conjecture that the existence of a specialized bound anaphor drives disjointness effects in pronouns (Reinhart 1983; Levinson 1987; Anderson 1992; Huang 2000; Safir

2004; Rooryck and Vanden Wyngaerd 2011).

It could be that, in the case of Biblical Hebrew, Principle B effects follow from the existence of a verbal reflexive strategy. The same argument would hold for the language of the Qur'an, which likewise features reflexive verb templates, and limits local readings of pronouns to a particular category of verbs known as *'af'āl al-qalb* 'verbs of the heart' (Wright 1898; Kayam 2024). For the current purposes, the crucial point is that merging the pronoun with a 'soul' expression in both these languages does not resolve a referential ambiguity (which does not exist in the first place) but rather introduces it.

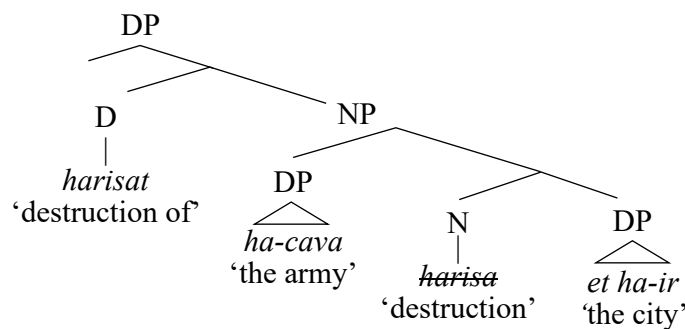
3.3 'soul' expressions are binding domains

Taken together, the data reported here and in classical philological studies of the examined sources lead to the conclusion that Hebrew and Arabic pronouns are limited to long-distance coreference, while 'soul' expressions can be long-distance or local. That is, the pronouns follow Principle B of the Binding Theory, which 'soul' expressions are free of. The reason for this contrast is straightforward: as possessive expressions, 'soul of x' may be construed as coreferential with a local subject without creating local binding in the syntactic sense. I will illustrate this below with a modern construct (specifically from Modern Hebrew), assuming a similar syntax for constructs in the Bible and the Qura'n.

As stated in Section 1.2, the standard analysis of nouns in the construct state in both Hebrew and Arabic assumes N to D raising that creates a position for a DP possessor, *ha-cava* 'the army' in (31). Depending on the choice of N, it can also have an internal argument, in this case an accusative DP.

(31) *harisat ha-cava et ha-ir*

'The army's destruction of the city'



Note first that these DP positions enable local binding between them, which cannot involve DPs outside the construct. This is evident below in the acceptability of an anaphor co-referring with 'the army' (32) but not with 'the president' (33). That is, the construct

behaves as its own binding domain. The next sentence then shows that a pronoun in this position can co-refer with the higher subject (34).

- (32) *harisat ha-cava₁ 'et 'acmo₁*
 destruction.of DET-army ACC itself
 'the army's destruction of itself' (Siloni 1997: 30)

- (33) *ha-nasi₁ hua 'šam be-[_{DP} harisat ha-cava₂ 'et 'acm-o*_{1/2}].*
 DET-president was.blamed in destruction.of DET-army ACC bone-3SG.M
 'The president₁ was responsible for the army's destruction of itself₁/*himself₁.'

- (34) *ha-nasi₁ tamax be-[_{DP} hasarat-o_{1/2} mi-rešimat ha-mu'amadim.*
 DET-army supported in removal.of -his from-list.of DET-candidates
 'The president supported his removal from the list of candidates.'

If pre-anaphoric 'soul' expressions follow the same structure, they would be as in (35), which should also constitute a binding domain. Biblical Hebrew and Classical Arabic are alike in this sense, apart from language-specific properties like the position that presents case.

- (35) *nafs-a-hu*
 soul-ACC-3SG.M
 'his soul'
-

When *nafs* expressions appear in object position, for example *juhlakun anfusahum* 'destroyed their souls', the pronominal suffix can establish coreference with the local subject while being itself locally disjoint in the DP. A schematic structure is shown in (36).

- (36) *juhlakun anfusahum*
 'they destroyed their souls'
-

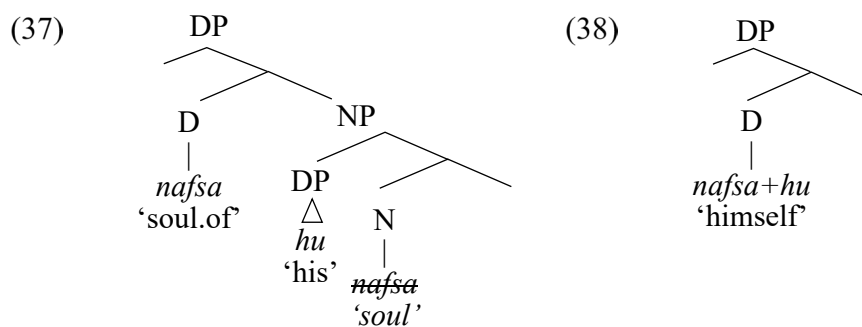
Thus, a phrase like ‘they destroyed their souls’, or a parallel with another body term that serves this purpose in Semitic languages (bone, head, etc.), generates a reflexive meaning without local binding: the subject is understood to act upon a part of its own self, but the suffix responsible to it is disjoint in the DP that forms its domain.

3.4 The economy of anaphors

To recap, I have shown that early varieties of Hebrew and Arabic employ ‘soul’ expressions in the construct state for local coreference. Philological work reports that pronouns are generally barred from such meanings, which means the ‘soul’ expressions have more referential options. Looking at productive construct states in Modern Hebrew explains why this is the case: nouns in the construct state behave as binding domains, restricting the interpretation of anaphors to antecedents within the construction. It is therefore expected that pronominal suffixes in this setting will escape the limits faced by bare pronouns.

This natural capacity for local coreference means that the anaphoric use of ‘soul’ does not emerge but rather is inherent to possessive body terms. Why, then, should languages that can express local coreference with body terms (alongside reflexive verb templates) shift toward a designated anaphor, such as Arabic *nafs-x* and Hebrew *acm-x*, in the modern varieties? I will conclude the current discussion by arguing that this change is motivated by economy, and that it facilitates the intensifier use of the anaphoric expression.

I so far assumed the classical construct state analysis following Ritter (1988), repeated below in (37), in which the noun ‘soul’ acquires a possessee meaning by raising to D. As an anaphor, I will assume that ‘soul’ is part of a bundle of features on D (38).



Again, I take Hebrew and Arabic to adhere to the same structure, abstracting away from the internal organization of the features on D and language-specific properties of accusative case marking.

A shift from the structure in (37) to that in (38) involves a reinterpretation of a moved element as base-generated and a reduction of a multi-word phrase into one head. These

processes are far from being unique, and are broadly argued for with respect to a collection of historical processes, under terms like univerbation (Lehmann 2020), syntactic reanalysis (Langacker 1977), and economy (Lightfoot 1979; Gelderen 2004; among many others). The shared insight of these studies is that speakers are motivated to choose simplified parses that reduce movement and merging operations to balance the computational load in language production and processing.

According to the data presented above, Biblical Hebrew shows no evidence for the existence of the simplified structure, but the Arabic of the Qura'n features some 59 instances of coreferential *nafs*-x in contexts that do not clearly fit its range of lexical meanings. Such occurrences are explained if the structure in (38) is available to the authors albeit with some restrictions (e.g., animacy). Table 6 summarizes the differences between the two Binding-Theory compliant structures.

	Structure	BT compliance	Lexical content	Restrictions
i.	Possessive 'soul' [DP <i>nafsa</i> [NP+ <i>hu</i> <i>nafs</i>]]	Principle B	Cognition/ Life	[+animate]
ii.	'soul' anaphor [DP <i>hu</i> [REFL]]	Principle A	—	—

Table 6: the makeup of suffixed 'soul' expressions in Arabic and Hebrew.

In the simplified analysis, 'soul' reads as a feature that makes a pronominal term visible to Principle A, akin to English *self*. Previous work explains this by analysing *self* as an identity statement between arguments (Reinhart and Reuland 1993; Antonenko 2012; Sauerland 2013; Bruening 2021, among others). This in turn explains the intensifying capacity of the same lexeme, if we assume that intensifiers are identity statement operating on focus alternatives (Moravcsik 1972; Eckardt 2001; Hole 2006; König and Gast 2006; Reuland and Winter 2009; Charnavel and Sportiche 2022). From this perspective, it is not a coincidence that intensifier uses of 'soul' appear in grammars that contain the bleached anaphoric variant, as they are fed by the identity interpretation of these lexemes.

In sum, the history of Arabic and Hebrew 'soul' anaphors presents a set of differences from the well-known history of English 'self': they are based on body terms rather than intensifiers; they do not reduce ambiguity but rather increase it; and their intensifier use follows the coreferential use instead of anticipating it. This collection of properties adds up to a rather straightforward process, in which body part constructs serve as readily available strategies to overcome Principle B biases in pronouns.

4. Conclusion

This paper looked at the relationship between anaphors and intensifier in Hebrew and Arabic in a historical perspective. I surveyed sources that predate the acceptance of the respective anaphors *nafs-x* and *acm-x* as the main reflexive strategies in these languages: The Hebrew Bible (1st millennium BCE) and the Qur'an (7th century CE). The results from both corpora suggested that coreferential uses of *nafs-x* and other body terms have been around in the possessive construct state before the adjectival intensifier appeared. Both completely lacked an adjectival use of *nafs*, but the Qur'an included a few DP instances of *naf-x* that seem to evoke an inference of focus alternatives. This development seems to have required a relatively well-established anaphoric use of *nafs-x* that breaks away from its lexical meaning, which is found in the Qur'an but not the Bible. This suggests that the anaphoric use of *nafs-x* feeds its intensifier use, the opposite of the direction documented in English, which means that intensifiers are not mere emphasis markers serving as building blocks for anaphors. Instead, anaphors and intensifiers have the same core meaning of identity expressions, designed for different types of input. These results make clear that anaphors are not just a response to the pragmatic pressure of having to resolve ambiguities, but a process that produces exponents for a fundamental grammatic operation of marking referential identity.

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Appendix A: coreferential occurrences of *nap̄š*

- (39) *raq hiššāmer lē-kā ū-šmor nap̄š-ekā me'od*
 only guard.2SG.M DAT-2SGM and-guard.2SG.M soul.of-2SG.M greatly
pen tiškaḥ 'et had-dəḥarīm 'ašer ra'ū 'ēynekā ...
 lest forget.2SG.M ACC the-things COMP see.3PL eye.of.PL-2SG.M
 'Only be careful, and watch {your souls/yourselves} closely so that you do not
 forget the things your eyes have seen...' (Deuteronomy 4.9)
- (40) *šabbat šabbātōn hī' lā- kem, we- 'innitēn 'et nap̄š-ōt-ēyxem*
 Sabbath sabbatical COP to-you and-afflict.3PL.M ACC soul.of-PL- 2PL.M
ḥuqqat 'ōlām.
 law.of eternity
 'It is a day of sabbath rest, and you must deny {your souls/yourselves}; it is a
 lasting ordinance.' (Leviticus 16.31)
- (41) *wə-šāma 'ābīhā 'et nidrāh, we- 'əsār-āh 'ašer*
 and-hear her.father ACC her.vow and-forbid.3SG.M-her that
'āsārāh 'al nap̄š-āh, wə-heḥēriš lāh
 forbid.3SG.F on soul.of- 3SG.F and-be.silent.3SG.M for.her
'ābīhā wə-qāmū kol nədārē-hā
 cease all vows.of-3SG.F
 'But if her father forbids her when he hears about it, none of her vows or the
 pledges by which she obligated {her soul/herself} will stand.' (Numbers 30.11)
- (42) *wə-lō təṭamm'ū 'et nap̄š-ōt-ēxem bə-kol haš-šereš*
 and-NEG defile.2PL.M ACC soul-PL-GEN.2PL.M in-all the-insect
hā-rōmēš 'al hā- 'āreš.
 COMP-swarm.3PL.M on the-ground
 'Do not make {your souls/yourselves} unclean by any creature that moves along the
 ground.' (Leviticus 11.44)
- (43) *hinnē hāyū kə-kaš 'ēš śrāfāt-am, lō yaššilū 'et*
 here were as-straw fire burn.3SG.F-them NEG save.3PL.M ACC
nap̄š-ām miy-yad lehāḥā;

soul-GEN.3PL.M from-hand.of flame

‘Surely they are like stubble; the fire will burn them up. They cannot even save
{their lives/themselves} from the power of the flame.’ (Isaiah 47.14)

- (44) *wə-nišmarttem mə'ōd lə-napš-ōt-ēxem kī lō rəṭtem*
and-keep.2PL.M much to-soul-PL-GEN.2PL.M COMP NEG saw.2PL.M
kōl tmūnāh bə-yōm dibber yəhwāh 'āl-ēykem bə-ḥōrēḥ,
any picture on-day speak.3SG.M Lord to-you in-Horev
mi-ttōk hā-'ēš.

from-within the-fire

‘You saw no form of any kind the day the Lord spoke to you at Horeb out of the
fire. Therefore watch {your souls/yourselves} very carefully.’ (Deuteronomy 4.15)

- (45) *yaḥsōk napš-ō, minnī-šāxaṭ; wə-ḥayyat-ō*
save.3SG.M soul-GEN.3SGM from-pit and-life-GEN.3SG.M
mē- 'āḥōr baš-šālah.

from-pass.INF in.the-sword

‘To preserve them from the pit, {their lives/themselves} from perishing
by the sword.’ (Job 33.18)